

이메일 도우미

Case Study · AI 201 Project 3: Persons Required

Eugina Han

SCAD · Spring 2026

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Email, for Mom.

Building a Gmail helper that meets her where the problem actually is.

What you'll see.

A defense, not a demo. The person. The problem. The build. The failures. The evidence of someone real using it.

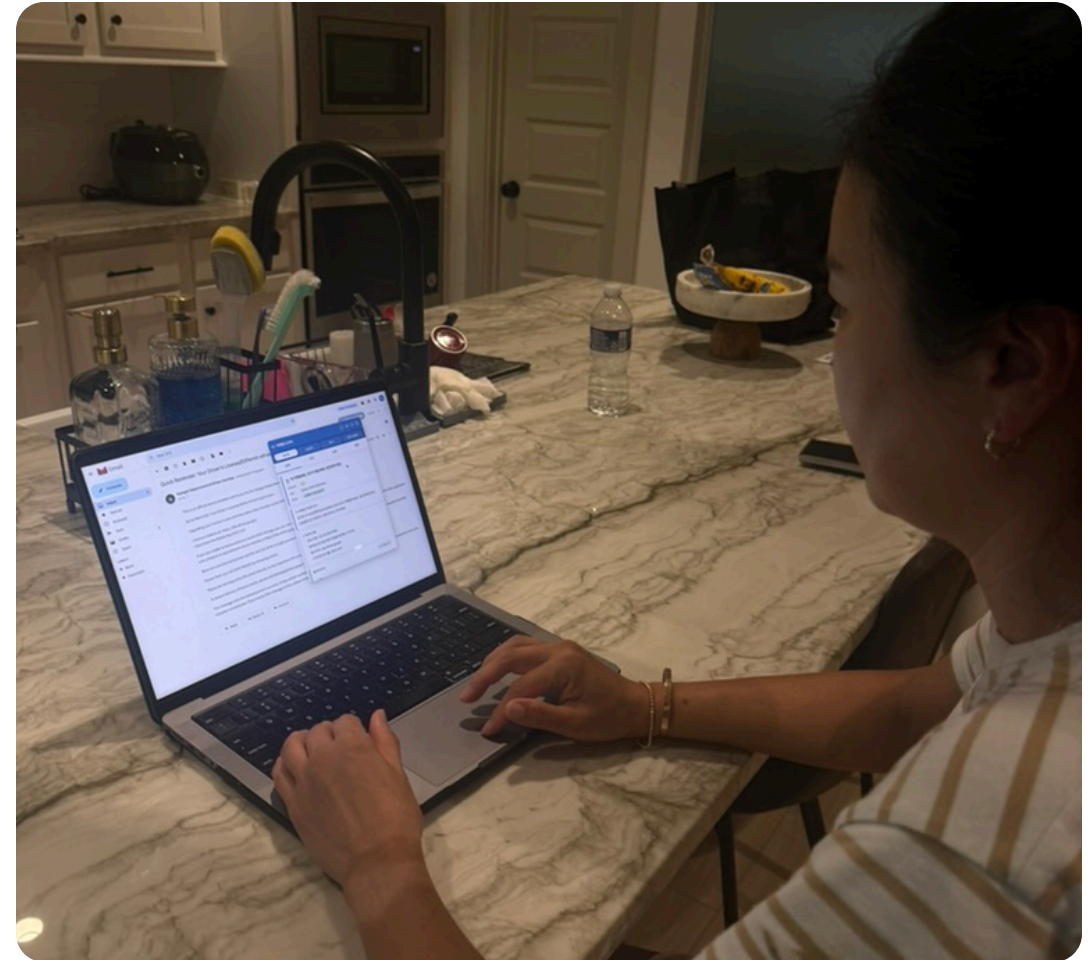
- 01 The Person
- 02 The Problem (in her words)
- 03 Research → Pain Points
- 04 Platform Decision
- 05 The Build
- 06 Prototype Failures
- 07 First Contact + Iteration

My mom.

A first-generation Korean immigrant who helps my dad manage franchise logistics. Some of the emails she handles are high-stakes: permits, bills, renewal notices, document requests.

She is not very comfortable with technology and faces a language barrier when reading emails in English. I'm usually the person she calls when she doesn't understand an email.

I'm not designing for a persona. I'm designing for one human being with a name and a face and a phone that buzzes me when she's stuck.



**"Sometimes I read the same email
over and over and still don't really
know what they want."**

MOM · FIELD INTERVIEW · SESSION 14

Where it breaks down.

Five pain points emerged from the interview and from watching her open real emails on her laptop and phone. Translation alone doesn't fix any of them. They're about uncertainty, emotional load, and never having a "what do I do now" answer.



Can't find the ask

Frequently asks *"what are they actually asking me to do?"* after reading.



Long emails = avoid

Long or formal emails get skimmed, then left unread "for later."



No follow-up system

Relies on memory or handwritten reminders. Most things slip.



App-switching tax

Bounces between email, Translate, calendar, and notes. Friction kills follow-through.



Fear of mistakes

Hesitates before replying because "I don't want to say the wrong thing."

In her own words.

Translated from Korean. Recorded during a casual conversation while she walked me through how she normally handles email at the kitchen island.

"If it looks stressful, I leave it and tell myself I'll come back later."

"I get nervous responding because I don't want to say the wrong thing."

"A lot of times I ask you to read it first before I answer."

"Some emails feel bigger or scarier than they actually are."

Why a Chrome extension.

The problem happens *inside email*. A separate app would mean copy-paste, context-switch, and another tool to learn. Three things that already kill her follow-through.

Not a mobile app: she reads email on both phone and laptop, and the deciding-what-to-do problem isn't mobile-specific.

Not a separate translation tool: Google Translate already gives her words. Words aren't her problem. Purpose and next steps are.

Not a chatbot: moving the solution off email adds steps instead of removing them.

Why a Chrome extension: it lives directly on top of Gmail. Same place she's already stuck.

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NEW APPS TO LEARN

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COPY-PASTE STEPS

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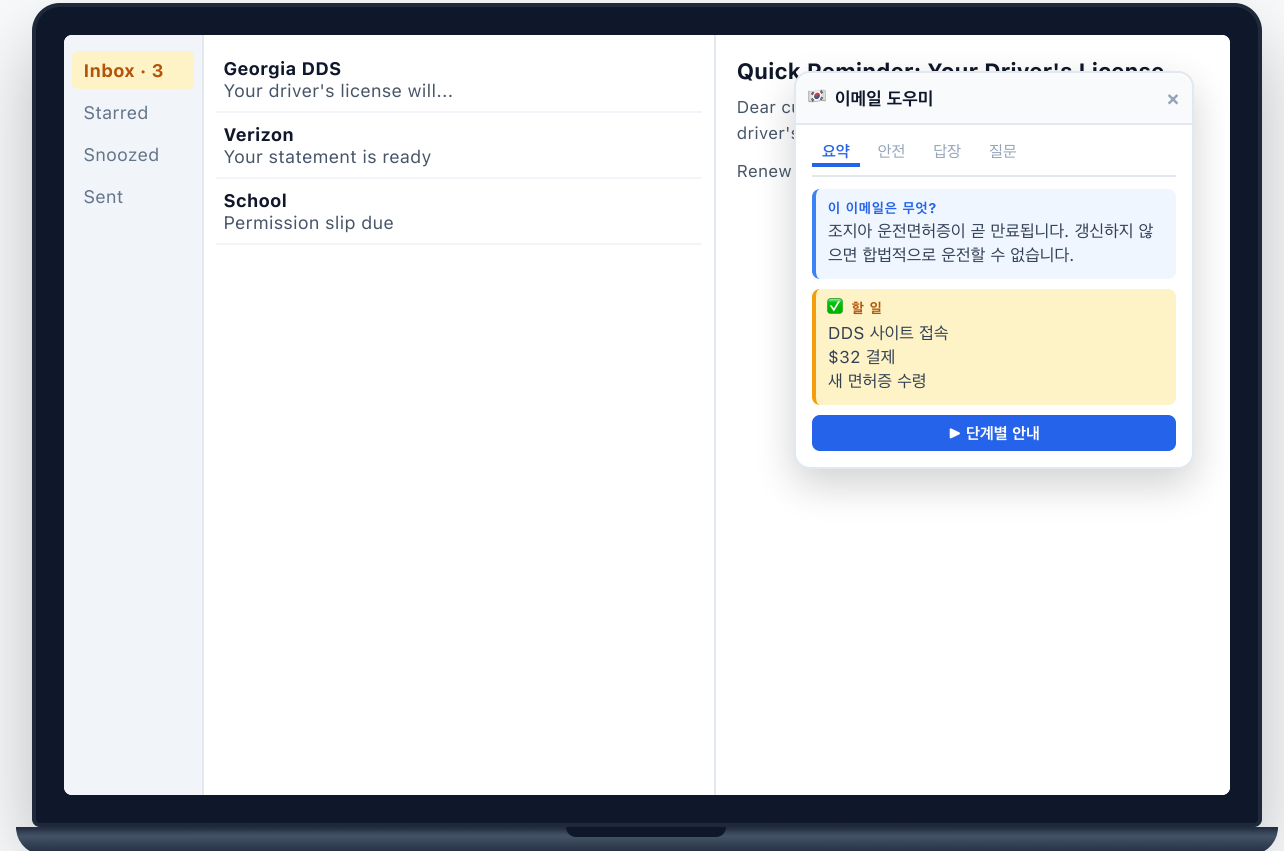
PLACE: WHERE SHE ALREADY IS

THE BUILD · OVERVIEW

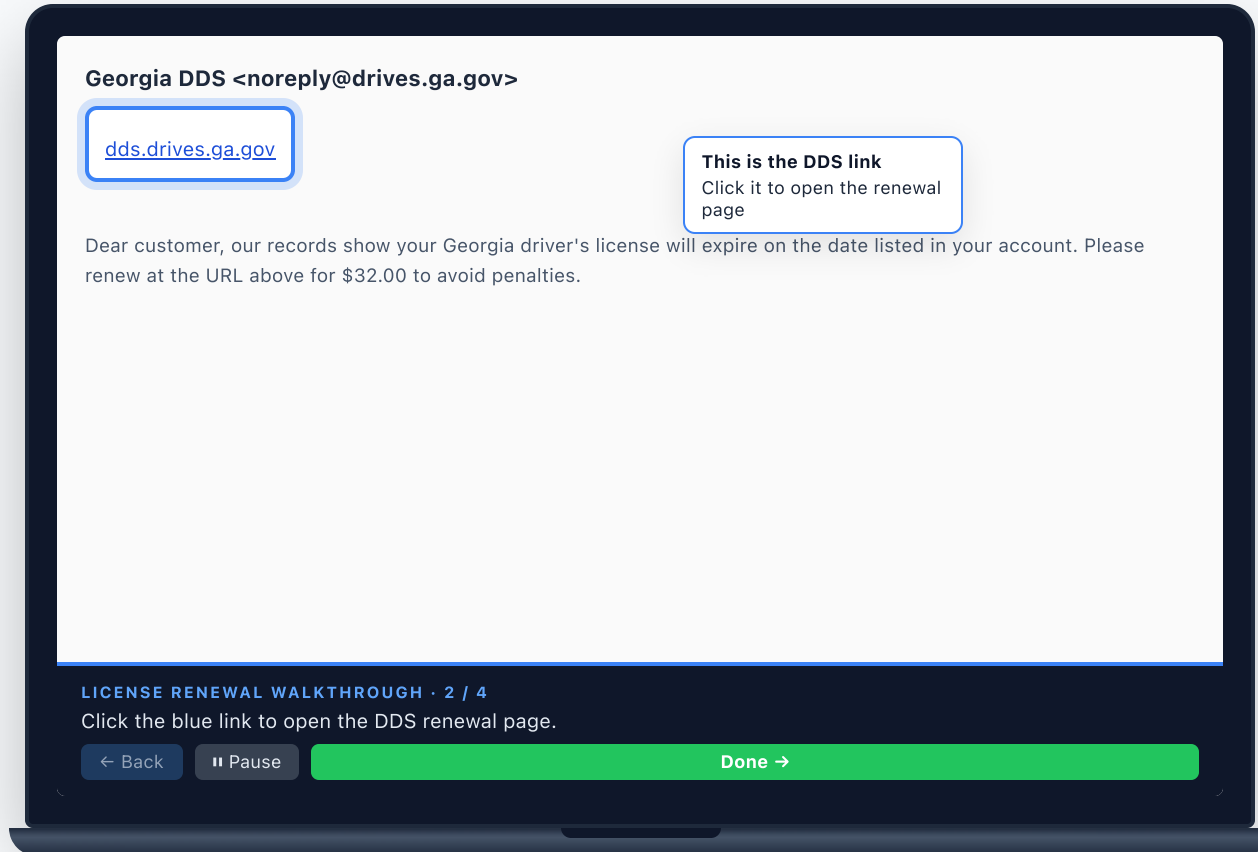
One panel, four tabs, thirteen features.

A floating panel that reads the live Gmail email she has open, classifies it, and answers *what does this mean, what should I do, when, and is it safe?* in the language she trusts.

- Floating · draggable · resizable · minimizable
- Four reading levels: Korean · English · Bilingual · Simple English
- Real Gmail DOM reading, no copy-paste
- Reminders persist in localStorage between sessions



The final extension on live Gmail.



Show me where spotlights the exact pixel she needs to click.

THE BUILD · FEATURE

"Show me where" + walkthrough mode.

The biggest insight from testing wasn't comprehension. It was hesitation. She'd *understand* what to do but freeze at "which thing do I click?"

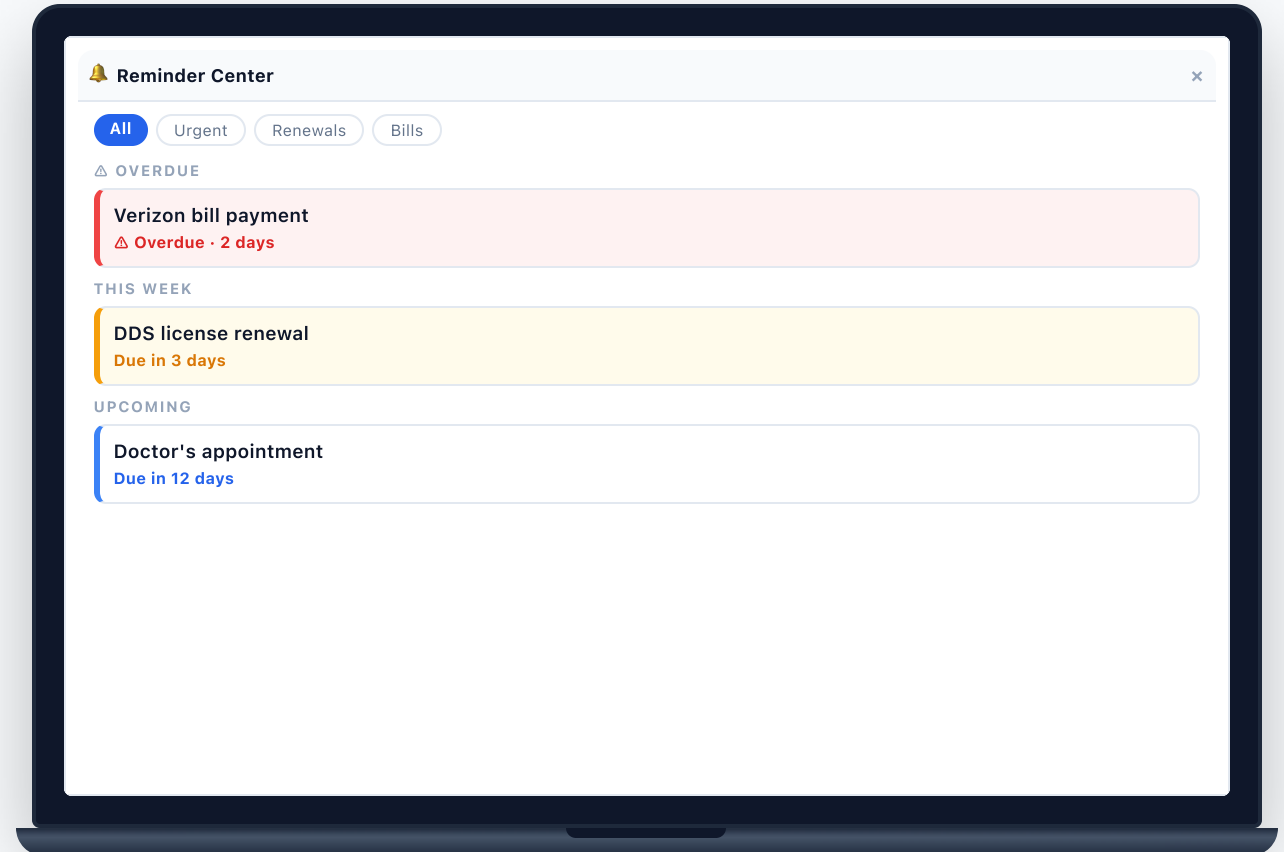
- Click "Show me where" → blue spotlight pulses on the exact element in the email
- "Start Walkthrough" runs the whole task step-by-step
- Tooltip lives to the left of the panel, never covers the email
- "I Need More Help" escalates to 5 calmer modes

THE BUILD · FEATURE

Reminders that actually have dates.

From the research: "I either leave the tab open or mark it unread and hope I remember." That's not a reminder system. That's a coping mechanism.

- Inline picker on every date: Tomorrow · Next Week · Custom
- Center groups them: Overdue · Today · This Week · Upcoming
- Countdown labels: "⚠ Overdue" · "Due in 3 days"
- Snooze 1 day · restart the walkthrough from the reminder



The Reminder Center. Every saved reminder has a **real due date**.

06 · THE RECEIPTS

Three versions that didn't work.

Each one shipped, each one failed in a different way, each one taught me something. The final build is the one that survived testing. The previous three are why.

FAILURE 01 · TOO MINIMAL

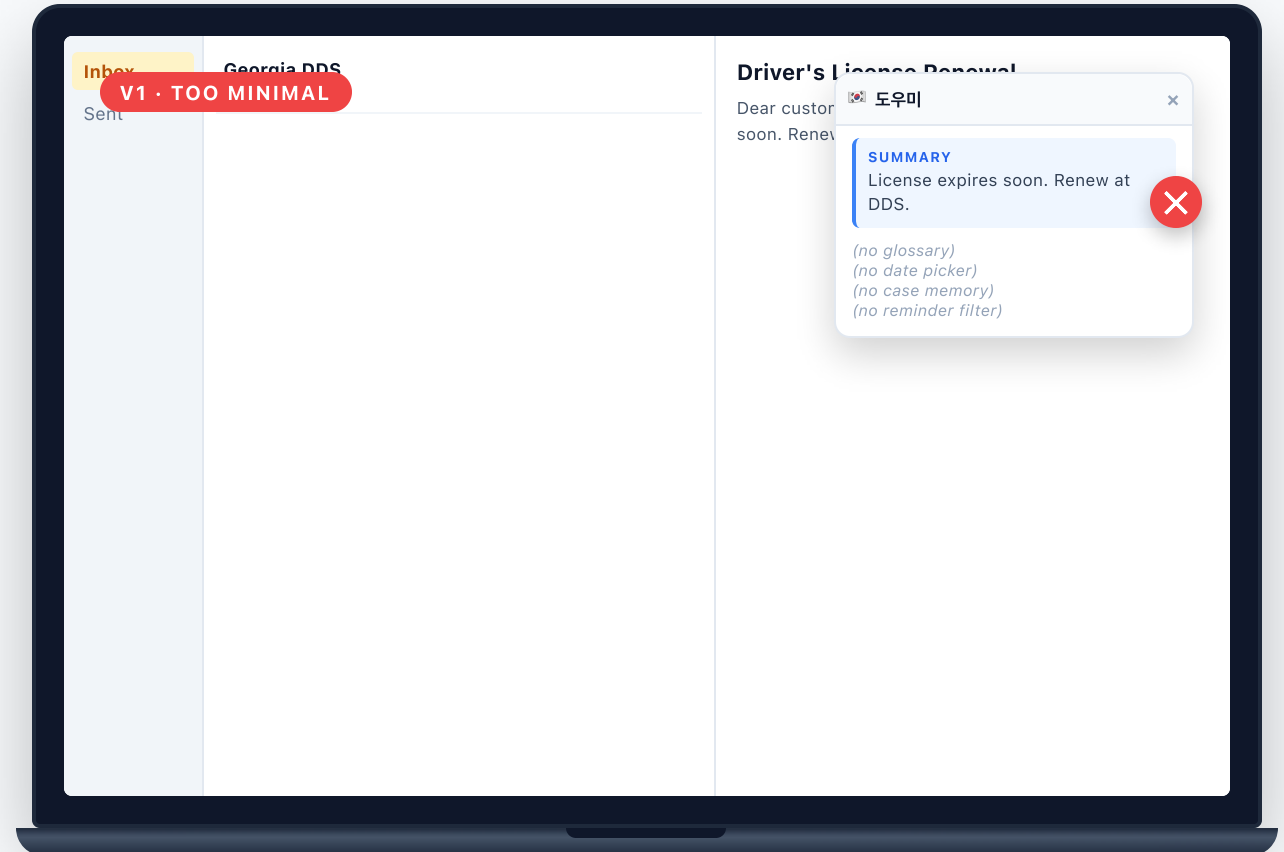
"Ship v1 first, expand later".

The first Chrome extension was a stripped-down version of the simulation: just a summary card and a 2-option escalation. No glossary, no date picker, no case memory, no reminder grouping.

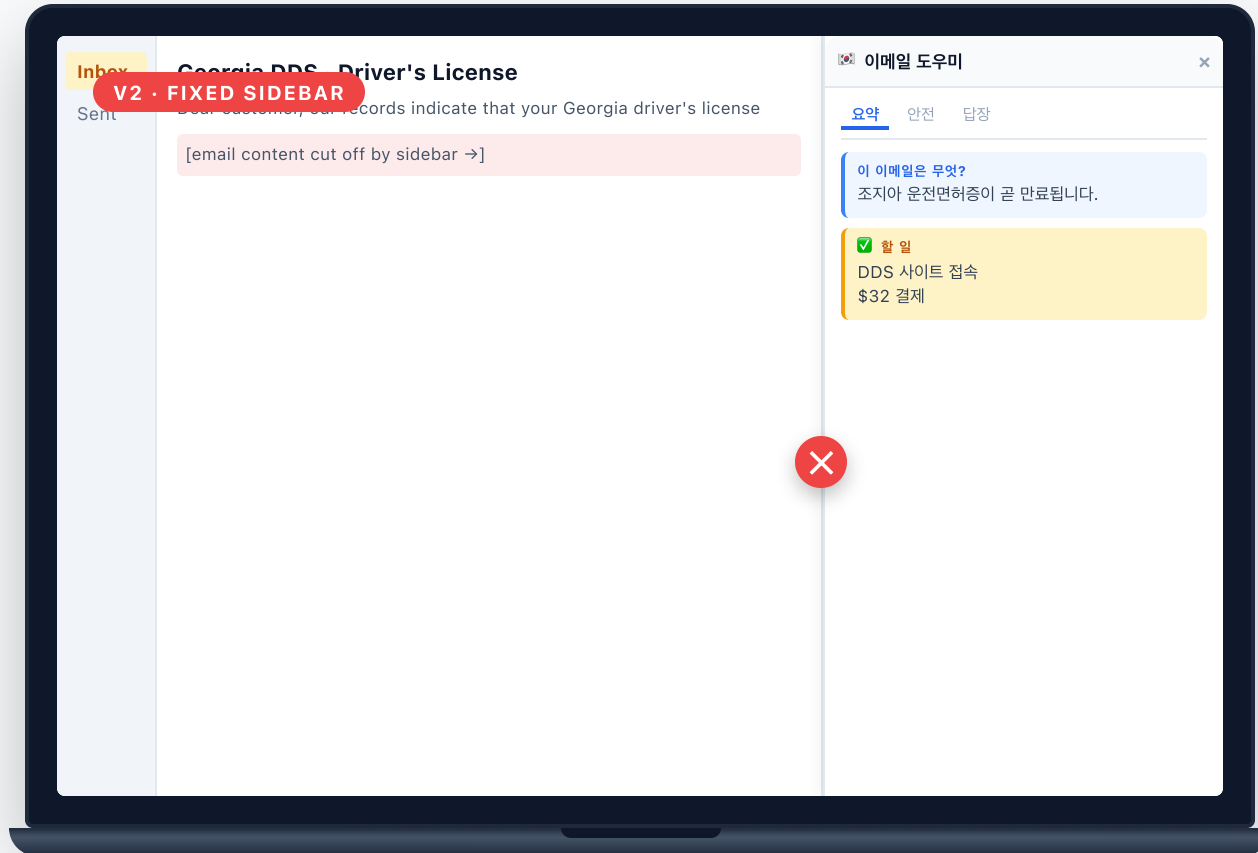
Why it failed:

The simulation she'd already seen in First Contact had all those features. Installing this on her real Gmail would have given her a worse tool than the demo. The whole point, "evidence that you helped someone," would have collapsed.

→ Rebuilt to full feature parity (~1700 lines).



Lesson: the extension is the deliverable. Don't ship a weaker version.



Lesson: "matches Grammarly" isn't a defense. **The panel can't cover the email.**

FAILURE 02 · COVERED THE EMAIL

The Grammarly sidebar fallacy.

Second version pinned the panel to the right edge of Gmail, full height. The reasoning: "this matches Grammarly and Gmail's own side panels."

Why it failed:

Mom's Gmail layout already has things on the right (Calendar, Tasks). A full-height fixed panel literally *covered the email she was trying to read*. The simulation she'd seen had a floating window. Switching to a sidebar made it feel like a different product and broke the trust she'd built.

→ **Rebuilt as floating window with 8 resize handles + minimize-to-pill.**

FAILURE 03 · REMINDERS WITH NO WHEN

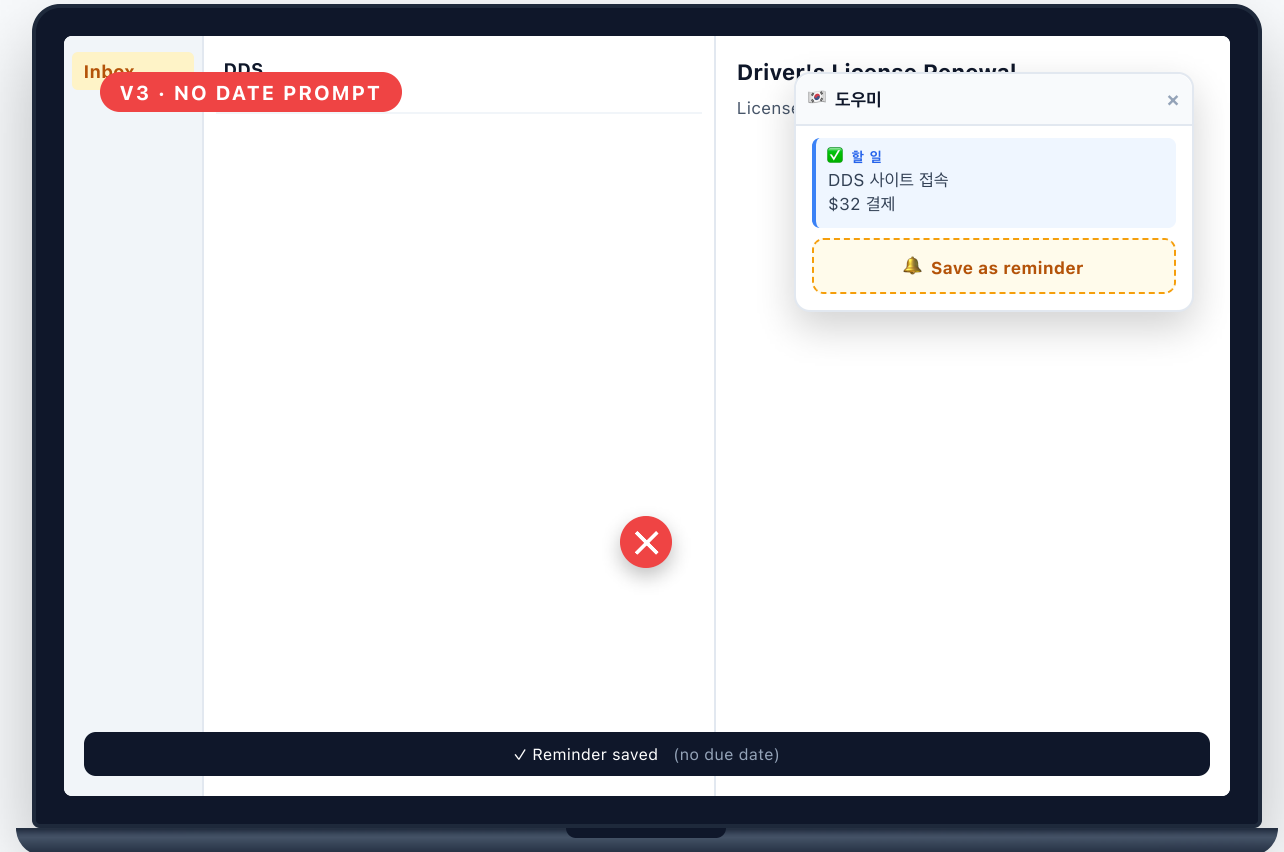
"Saved!" isn't a reminder.

"Save this email as a reminder" auto-saved with no date prompt. One click, a toast appeared, done. AI defended this as "cleaner UX, mom shouldn't have to think about when."

Why it failed:

The whole reason she misses things isn't that she doesn't want to set reminders. It's that *"I'll deal with this later"* never has a when attached, so later never comes. A reminder with no date lives in "Upcoming" forever. Functionally identical to no reminder.

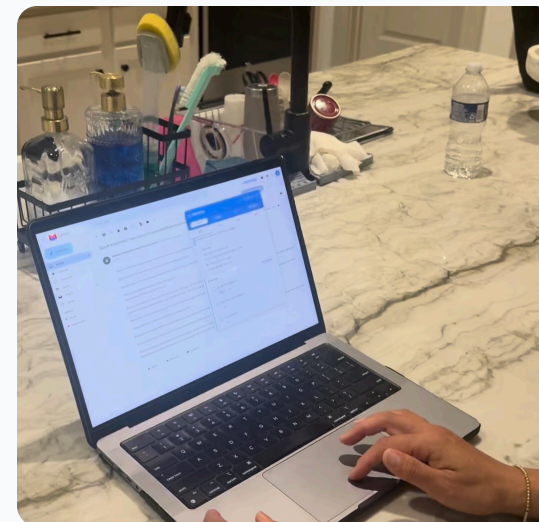
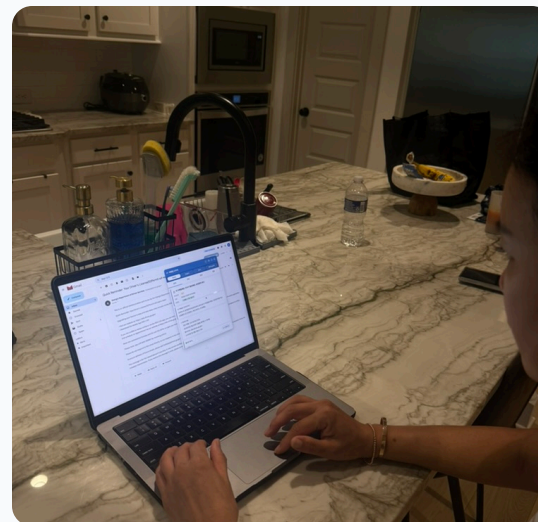
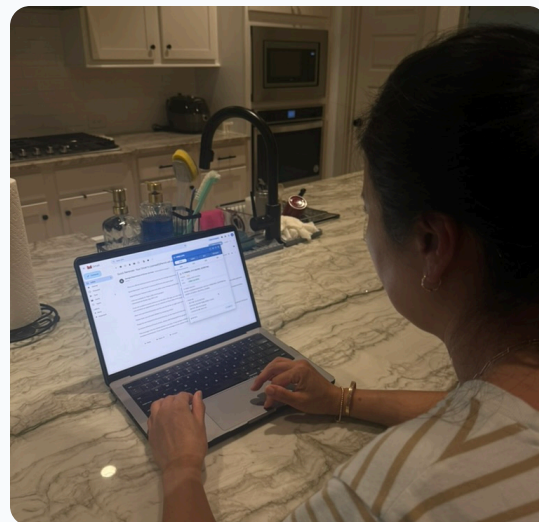
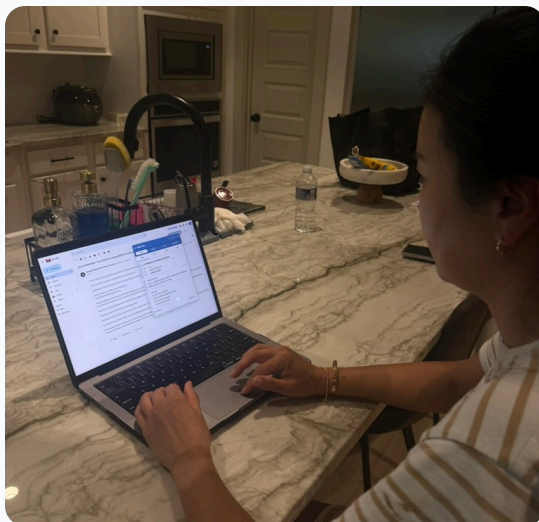
→ Rebuilt the button to open the same picker as the date cards.



Lesson: a reminder with no when is functionally identical to no reminder.

The moment it had to work.

Not a classmate. Not a demo at the studio. Mom on her actual laptop in her actual kitchen with a real email open. This is the moment the tool was either useful or noise.
She didn't ask me to translate it.



What testing changed.

Every observation from First Contact mapped to a specific change in the build.

She immediately understood simplified action sections	→	Kept simplified mode but narrowed it: only hides dense list-style cards, not the supportive sections (Glossary, Case Memory)
Calmer, conversational language worked	→	Korean tone locked to 해요체, polite but not stiff. Emoji used sparingly to signal type, not decorate
Reminder feature felt intuitive without explanation	→	Date picker promoted from a hidden secondary action to a prominent button on every detected date + a "Save email as reminder" button on every checklist
Wanted a clearer place to revisit saved reminders	→	Built the Reminder Center: filter pills (All / Urgent / Renewals / Appointments / Bills), grouped by Overdue / Today / This Week / Upcoming with countdown labels and snooze
Asked for more guidance when she felt unsure	→	Added "I Need More Help" escalation flow with 5 modes (cant-find · slower · scared · dont-understand · human) + enhanced guide highlight with bouncing arrow

WHAT I LEARNED

Hypothetical users let you off the hook. A real person you know doesn't. She just doesn't click the button you spent two hours on, and her face tells you why before she can articulate it.

Designing for one person didn't make the product narrower. It made it sharper. The features that solve mom's specific problem are the same ones that would help anyone else navigating an unfamiliar language inside an unfamiliar bureaucracy. The opposite path, designing for "all immigrant users," would have produced a vaguer, more compromised tool.

THANK YOU

She didn't call me.

The first time mom used the extension on her own Gmail, she didn't ask me to translate the email. She opened it, read the Korean summary, set a reminder for Tuesday, and closed the tab. That's the deliverable.

Live URL: euginahan.github.io/PersonsRequired_Claude

Repo: github.com/euginahan/PersonsRequired_Claude